

WEEK 1 LESSON GUIDE

**STICK
TOGETHER**

BIG IDEA

Every friend will influence you.

BIBLE

Proverbs 12:26; Acts 18:1–4,
18–28; Hebrews 13:1

ABOUT THIS WEEK

The most legendary adventure stories reach a point when one character helps another discover their potential. This week, we'll see how Priscilla and Aquila shared what they knew about Jesus with Apollos to empower him to share the good news. Their story shows us how important it is to have friends who help us grow because **every friend will influence you.**

WHAT? What are we talking about?



See the
Accessibility Hacks



QUESTION | What's your favorite adventure movie?

- Welcome to *Stick Together*, a new series that's all about friendship... and adventure, too.
 - Think about your favorite adventure movies, like *Indiana Jones*, *Jumanji*, *Jurassic Park*—so many! These stories all have evil villains, dangerous terrain, daring adventures, and heart-stopping thrills.
 - But do you know what else they have in common? Friends. Friends who look out for each other—especially when things get scary.
- **What's your favorite adventure movie?**
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Give a few students a chance to respond. Keep the conversation flowing by asking follow-up questions like...
 - **Who are the "good guys"?**
 - **What kind of quest are they on?**
 - **Tell us about one scene where they help each other out of danger.**
 - **What's the craziest thing they do to survive or accomplish their mission?**



See the Hacks



VIDEO | A Clip From *Jumanji: Welcome to the Jungle*

- Something I love about these movies is that you'll inevitably have a scene where one character gets convinced to do something wild. Maybe they get convinced to take a risk, join a quest, or leap off a crumbling ledge just in time. Whatever it is, the point is their friends have to convince them to do it.
- I'll show you an example. In *Jumanji: Welcome to the Jungle*, we've got four high schoolers named Martha, Spencer, Anthony (Fridge), and Bethany. They have absolutely nothing in common... except that they all get detention on the same day, find an old video game, and—you guessed it—convince each other to play it.



See the
Accessibility Hacks



- **INSTRUCTIONS:** As a teaching tool, play a short clip like [this one](#) (7:15–8:30) from *Jumanji: Welcome to the Jungle*. We always suggest viewing the clip beforehand to ensure it's a good fit for your context! [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes!

DISCUSSION | How did they end up playing this game together?

- This clip is pretty interesting, and not just because they all turned into floating particles and got sucked into a video game. It's interesting because of how they convinced each other to play in the first place!
- These kids barely know each other. They don't really like each other. And they're all so different.
 - Martha is a bookworm who's super-focused on getting into Princeton.
 - Spencer is the geekiest kid in school with asthma and a love of video games.
 - Anthony (Fridge) is a football star who convinces Spencer to do his homework for him.
 - Bethany is the popular girl who's really into being pretty.
- So what do you think? **How did they end up playing this game together?**
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Give a few students a chance to respond. Add clarity or dimension with follow-up questions like...
 - **What do you think made them all decide to play?**
 - **Why do you think Martha wasn't interested in playing at first?**
 - **Why do you think Martha eventually gave in?**



See the Hacks



VIDEO | A Clip from *Jumanji: Welcome to the Jungle*

- Of course, these characters *thought* they were just convincing each other to play a video game. But they ended up getting sucked into a pretty surprising adventure.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** As a teaching tool, play [a short clip like this one](#) (0:18–0:48) from *Jumanji: Welcome to the Jungle*. We always suggest viewing the clip beforehand to ensure it's a good fit for your context! [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes!
- If you've seen the movie, you know these characters influenced each other in a lot of ways. Sometimes, that meant getting each other into life-threatening danger (oops!). Other times, they influenced each other in ways that helped everyone grow.
- Maybe you can relate—not to turning into a real-life video game avatar, but to being influenced by someone in a way you didn't expect. Maybe someone influenced you to...
 - Try something new.
 - Like something you thought you hated.
 - Get to know someone you wouldn't usually talk to.
 - Do something you regretted.
 - Do something that helped you grow.
 - Join an epic jungle quest without adult supervision.
- Today, we're going to talk about how our friends influence us, how we influence them, and how God might want us to think about all of it.

SO WHAT? Why does it matter to God and to us?

See the Middle
School Hacks

**STORY | Talk about a time a friend influenced you in a small way.**

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Tell a story (or ask a volunteer or student to tell a story) about a time a friend influenced you to do, think, or believe something. Keep this story lighthearted, with an example involving something like your taste in music, trying a new food or hobby, or doing something out of your comfort zone.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.
 - **What's something you started liking because of a friend's influence?**
What's something you stopped liking because of a friend's influence?
 - * **Has a friend ever influenced you to make a positive change in your life? What happened?**
 - * **Has a friend ever influenced you to do something you later regretted? What did you learn from that experience?**



See the Middle
School Hacks

**OBJECT LESSON | Friendship Tug-of-War (Part 1)**

- You've probably heard the word "influence" before. Maybe you've...
 - Been told to be a good influence.
 - Been warned about bad influences.
 - Or wanted to be an "influencer."
- "Influence" shows up in every relationship—both the close and the casual ones. People influence us and we influence them. Sometimes that pull is really strong and sometimes it's not.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** For this object lesson, you'll need at least five lengths of [rope](#). Call a few students or volunteers to the front (one for each rope). One at a time, ask them to hold one end of the rope, while you hold the other, and pull. Experiment with different people of different strengths and different degrees of force to show how different people can have different amounts of influence. Then hold all the ropes while everyone pulls—first in different directions, then all in the same direction—while you try to hold your ground.
- We're always being influenced—but usually, it's the people closest to us who influence us the most. And when a group is pulling in the same direction? That influence multiplies. That's why it matters...
 - Who is influencing us (and who we're influencing).
 - How they're influencing us (and how we're influencing them).
 - Where all those influences combined are leading us and our friends.
- Because if we're not wise about who's influencing us, and how we're influencing others, our relationships might end up leading us somewhere we never intended to go.



See the High
School Hacks



SCRIPTURE | Proverbs 12:26

- There's a book of the Bible you may have heard of called Proverbs. It's a whole book of wise sayings designed to help us discover more of God's wisdom.
- This book covers so much—from handling money, to following God's ways, to building better friendships. Like this verse...
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Proverbs 12:26.
- Think for a second about your closest friends. How did you become friends in the first place? You probably shared a class, or lived on the same street, or met them through another friend, right? Sometimes it feels like friendships just happen by chance.
 - So when this verse says godly people "choose their friends carefully," you might wonder, "Uh, where is this list of available friend profiles I can scroll through? Because I want to go friend-shopping." Unfortunately, that's not really how friendships work.
 - But here's what God is saying through this verse: be wise about the people you spend time with, because friendships are powerful.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.
 - * **What are some challenges you face when it comes to finding friends who are good influences?**
 - **On a scale of 1–5, how "good" of an influence do you think your friends are? How do you think your friends would rate you?**

OBJECT LESSON | Friendship Tug-of-War (Part 2)

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Before you read the following Scripture, invite a few students to the front to symbolize the following people: Paul, Aquila, Priscilla, and Apollos. If your numbers allow, assign groups of students to be the people of Corinth, Syria, Ephesus, Jerusalem, Antioch, Galatia, Phrygia, and Achaia. (The groups of students can remain in their seats while holding the [ropes](#).) As you read the passage and introduce new characters, give them each a [rope](#) to illustrate their influence on other characters.

SCRIPTURE | Acts 18:1–4, 18–28

- There are plenty of Bible stories where people totally mess up their lives by following the wrong influences. And honestly, it's probably easy to think of real-life examples of that, too.
- But today I want to show you the opposite. I want to introduce you to a few people from history whose influence—on each other and on the world—changed countless lives (and the world) forever.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Acts 18:1–4, 18–28. As you read, follow these prompts to connect the passage with the object lesson above:
 - 1: Bring "Paul" to the center.

- 2: Add "Aquila" and "Priscilla." Connect them with three ropes in a triangle formation.
- 3: Ask all three to gently pull on their ropes to show their influence on each other.
- 4: Connect "Paul" and "the people of Corinth."
- 18: Connect "Paul" and "the people of Syria."
- 19: Connect "Paul," "Aquila," and "Priscilla" each to "the people of Ephesus."
- 22: Connect "Paul" to "the people of Jerusalem and Antioch."
- 23: Connect "Paul" to "the people of Galatia and Phrygia."
- 24: Add "Apollos." Connect him to "Aquila," "Priscilla," and "the people of Ephesus" with three more ropes.
- 27: Connect "Apollos" to "the people of Antioch."
- 28: At the end of the passage, have "Paul," "Aquila," "Priscilla," and "Apollos" all walk and pull their ropes gently in the same direction so everyone holding the ropes feel their influence.
- Do you see it? God took a small group of friends and used them to create a giant web of influence. Because of them, people in all of these cities heard and experienced the good news of Jesus.
- And while this story might sound extraordinary, it's actually full of things we can relate to:
 - Aquila and Priscilla had to move to a new town and make new friends
 - They connected with Paul because they shared a hobby.
 - Their friendship grew while they made tents together.
 - Eventually, one got busy and couldn't hang out for awhile.
 - Later, they met a new guy, Apollos, and invited him to hang out—and he said yes.
- See what I mean? These are regular people just like us. It's not the story of a few extraordinary people—it's the story of a whole community of ordinary people that, through friendship, made a big difference for Jesus. The gospel didn't just spread through sermons—it spread through shared work, shared meals, and the influence found in friendship.



See the Middle
School Hacks



Share your story



STORY | Talk about a time you and a friend influenced each other to grow in your faith.

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Share a story (or invite a volunteer or student to share one) about a time you influenced a friend, a friend influenced you, or you both influenced each other to grow in your faith. Tell how your friendship started and how your influence in each other's lives grew over time. Then get specific—how did that influence actually move you closer to Jesus?
- Choosing friends isn't always simple or easy. But even when it's not, we get to decide who we let influence us—and who we influence back.
- For good, or for bad, our friendships have the power to shape what we like, how we think, how we behave, and even what we believe. So when you have a chance to choose, choose wisely, because **every friend will influence you.**

NOW WHAT? What does God want us to do about it?**DISCUSSION**

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.
 - **What are some of the ways Paul, Aquila, Priscilla, and Apollos influenced each other?**
 - **In what ways are you and your friends already like these friends? In what ways could you still learn from them?**
 - *** Do you and your friends ever talk about how you can influence others to know Jesus better? Why or why not?**



Spend Time
With Others

**REFLECTION | Illustrated Influence**

- So what does your friend group look like?
 - How are your friends influencing you?
 - How are you influencing your friends?
 - And when all of that is combined, is your friend group like Paul, Aquila, Priscilla, and Apollos—moving toward Jesus (and bringing others with you)? Or are you moving in a different direction?
- We're going to take a few minutes to visualize this by doodling. You don't have to share yours if you don't want to. What matters is that, as you draw, you're thinking about how you and your friends influence each other. Think about how you and your friends influence each other's...
 - Attitudes.
 - Words.
 - Actions.
 - Habits.
 - Opinions.
 - Faith.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Before your teaching time, print the [handouts](#) provided in your Week 1 folder and place one under each seat, with a pen. Reread Proverbs 12:26, then invite students to draw stick figures or bubbles representing their friends. Use arrows to show who's influencing who and how much. The stronger the influence, the bolder and bigger the arrow. Make sure they show both how their friends influence them and how they believe they influence their friends.
- Now that you have a little diagram of your friendships and their influence, I want to give you three words to help you think about what's next.
 - **ADD:** Who can you add to your circle to help influence everyone for the better? Is there someone you've been nervous to talk to? Someone you want to learn from? Do you have lots of friends—but not many who help you move closer to Jesus? Who can you add?
 - **SUBTRACT:** Nobody's a perfect influence (not even you or me). But sometimes, we need to "subtract." We don't need to cut people off every time they mess up, but are there friends you need to spend a little less

time with? Are there any relationships that really do need to end because of the unhealthy ways you influence each other, or is there still time to turn things around?

- **MULTIPLY:** Are you spending so much time with people who think and believe the same things you do that you don't have any influence with people who don't know Jesus? (What if Paul and his crew had done that?! They wouldn't have a story to tell!) Instead, how can you and your friends work together to "multiply" the good news of Jesus in the world? How can you "multiply" your influence to make a bigger difference, together?

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.*
 - **Read Hebrews 13:1. When we love each other well, what kind of impact do you think that could make?**
 - **This week, how could you be a better influence on others—especially your friends? How could you surround yourself with more influences that help you grow?**



Use your Gifts



RESPONSE | "Thank You for Influencing Me" Cards

- Over the next few weeks, we're going to talk a lot more about what it means to be and have friends who influence each other in healthy, godly ways. But for now, let's wrap things up by celebrating the friends who are already influencing us for the better. Maybe they influenced you to...
 - Listen to a new song you're now obsessed with.
 - Try something that scared you (but you're glad you did it).
 - Start a new habit that's helped you grow.
 - Or see God in a brand new way.
- Whatever good this person influenced you to do, think, believe, or be... say thank you! **Every friend will influence you.** So when you have a friend who's influencing you for good, make sure you stick together.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Before your teaching time, print the [handout](#) provided in your Week 1 folder on card stock and cut them into individual cards. Place the blank cards in a large [basket](#) or [bucket](#). As students are leaving, invite them to take as many cards as they'd like, fill them out, and give them to the people they are thanking.*